



Drawing first blood: India's Shailand Lakra (99) fires the opener against China in the Hero Asia Cup men's hockey clash in Rajgir. R. V. MOORTHY

decisive force.

Right-back Jarmanpreet Singh emerged as another unexpected attacking engine, his overlapping runs and deft first touch setting up teammates like Sukhjeet Singh, Abhishek, Manpreet Singh, Dilpreet, and Shilanand.

India finished with a staggering 39 goals, the highest by any team, though the overall lack of quality opposition undoubtedly helped inflate the tally.

State of Asian Hockey

The tournament also laid bare the gulf in Asian hockey. China showed flashes of ambition, while Malaysia, Korea, and Japan pushed hard, but the gap to India was obvious.

"While teams like Malaysia, Korea, Japan, and China are capable of winning on a given day, India is a

level above all of them," observed Malaysia coach Sarjit Kundan.

Without Pro League exposure, Asian teams rarely face the world's best. For lower-ranked sides such as Bangladesh, Chinese Taipei, and Kazakhstan, the problem is worse; they last played in April at the AFH

Cup 2025.

"If we could have leagues in Asia, like the European Championships, where there are different tiers, the weaker teams could play among themselves and then get promoted to the top tier. It would be hugely beneficial for smaller teams like us,"



The victory brings relief after a disastrous European leg of the Pro League 2024-25. With an average of more than 5.5 goals per game, India sparkled in what head coach Craig Fulton had called the "most important tournament of the year."